



Buddhism in Practice

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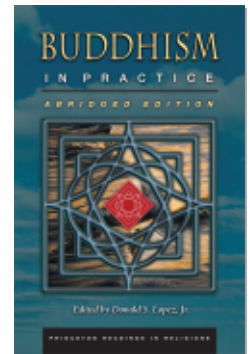
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Atiśa's Journey to Sumatra

Hubert Decleer

According to his traditional biographies, the Indian master Atiśa (the author of the text translated in Chapter 17) left India for some years in order to study under the tutelage of the monk Dharmakīrti (also known as Guru Suvarṇadvīpa) on the island of Sumatra. This is an account of his voyage. The story is noteworthy for a number of reasons. First, it is an example of an account of a Buddhist traveler who sets out on a long and perilous journey in search of the dharma. The most famous of these journeys are those of Chinese monks going to India or Japanese monks going to China. Here, however, we have a case of an Indian monk leaving India, the homeland of Buddhism, to seek a teacher more learned than any to be found in India. This may suggest something of the state of Buddhist learning in India at the beginning of the eleventh century. Indeed, at the time of his departure for Tibet, Atiśa is reported to have stated: “In all of India, those who knew all the subtleties in the philosophical systems of both Outsiders [non-Buddhists] and Insiders [Buddhists] were only four: Guru Suvarṇadvīpa of Golden Island [Dharmakīrti], Śāntipa [Ratnākaraśānti], myself, and my disciple Kṣitigarbha; besides these four, there was no one else.”

Like the journeys of other pilgrims, Atiśa's route is fraught with dangers from supernatural forces. On the journey to Sumatra, Atiśa's ship was tossed about in a great tempest and then becalmed by the god Śiva, here called Maheśvara, the “Great Lord.” Śiva is apparently angry that Atiśa has left India in pursuit of the Buddhist dharma and is seeking to stop him. In response, Atiśa, who was to become renowned in Tibet as a teacher of compassion, performs a wrathful act of destructive magic. He and his disciple Kṣitigarbha manifest themselves as wrathful tantric deities to defeat Śiva and his consort. After this immediate threat is averted, Kṣitigarbha, with the blessings of the female bodhisattva of compassion, Tārā, launches a preemptive strike against the enemies of Buddhism, including Hindus, Muslims, and practitioners of the Bön religion of Tibet. Atiśa, living in

the century that saw the beginnings of what was to be the wholesale destruction of the Buddhism on the Indian subcontinent, is portrayed as the last champion of the dharma.

In the account, when Atiśa correctly identifies the danger as Maheśvara, the god Śiva, he tries to appease him by entering a samādhi from which he could not be disturbed by normal means: a meditation on loving-kindness (*maitri*) and compassion (*karuṇā*). His disciple knows better, and realizes he has to call in all the deities with whom he has established a relationship by previous meditational practice. They include first, the Slayer of Death (Yamāntaka), the bull-headed wrathful form of the bodhisattva of wisdom, Mañjuśrī, who appears to be Kṣitigarbha's personal deity, and the ten Wrathful Ones of his entourage, with two mentioned specifically: the Invincible by Others (Aparājita) and the Immovable (Acala). Next Kṣitigarbha calls on Tārā, the goddess famed for fast response in situations of extreme danger, as well as various protector deities, such as Dharmarāja with the buffalo head. Kṣitigarbha's prayer is, however, in the first place addressed to his guru, Atiśa, who now responds by transforming himself into the Red Slayer of Death (Yamāri). When the sea monster appears as an emaciated girl, she is in fact Carcika (Caṇḍikā, a form of Śiva's consort Durgā), the goddess mentioned later and against whose promises the Tārās give Atiśa a serious warning. It is Maheśvara, the Great Lord himself, who next appears from the kitchen hearth on board, and with an unusual foreknowledge he proposes a deal to Atiśa: if Atiśa promises not to go to Tibet (something which Atiśa himself has no idea about as yet), or to visit islands like Sri Lanka, Maheśvara will end the storm and allow him to return to northern India. Mistakenly viewing Atiśa in his appearance of the Slayer of Death as a mere yakṣa (a minor earth spirit) Maheśvara rounds off his discourse with a mantra addressed to a yakṣa and becalms the ship.

In reply and while still manifesting himself as the Red Slayer of Death, Atiśa emanates one of his wrathful entourage, Acala the Immovable, to get the ship to move. At this moment, the personal deity of Atiśa since innumerable lifetimes, who had manifested herself since his early childhood, Tārā the Savioress, appears in all her twenty-one forms simultaneously, and Atiśa offers salutation to four of the forms. They mildly rebuke him for not having called on them in his moment of danger, especially since shipwreck is one of the eight terrors against which Tārā specializes. Fortunately his disciple Kṣitigarbha had called on them, hence their response. To Kṣitigarbha they entrust the wrathful action against the main enemies of the dharma—at which point we must remember that in his earlier urgent prayer the disciple of Atiśa had first invoked his guru, immediately followed by an appeal to the same Slayer of Death, two of whose ten Kings of Wrath attendants (Invincible by Others and Immovable) he mentioned by name; here a third one, Horseneck Hāyagrīva, later mentioned in the "Words of Divine Pride," seems to perform the action, with the disciple staying himself in self-generation as the Slayer of Death Yamāntaka, and emanating that particular attendant, whose mantra is spelled out.

Not all of the enemies that Kṣitigarbha attacks can be clearly identified. The Tīrthika (non-Buddhist) temple of Maheśvara could be situated just about anywhere; the site is first given as *Svabha-thana*, apparently *Svabhāva-sthāna*, “the Self-Arisen Throne Seat,” and later as *Svabhanatha*, apparently *Svabhāva-Nātha*, “The Spontaneously Arisen Lord” or “The Self-Existing Lord.” The Carcika image appears to be in the same temple complex and is destroyed first, possibly as it is closely associated with heavy blood sacrifice. The Turuka palace of the Mongol hordes relates to the Afghan borderlands: “Turuka” refers to their ancestral lands some centuries before. His “stopping them from reaching [and raiding] the Vajra Throne” refers to the eventual attack of these troops on the temples at Bodhgayā, the site of the Buddha’s enlightenment. Shang-shung, the location of the Black Tent palace of the king of Shang-shung, is the traditional place of origin of Bön, Tibet’s pre-Buddhist religion, variously situated anywhere between southwest Tibet and Iran. The famous Tibetan epic *Gesar of Ling* is in fact devoted to a hero who wipes out entire cultures obsessed with the blacker forms of magic. The poison lake (or sea) in the south, from which leprosy spread, remains a mystery, but the country Lanka of the rakṣasa cannibal-demons is Sri Lanka, which had a long tradition of such practices; the hero Siṃhala, after whom the island used to be called Ceylon, escaped the enticing sirens that were in fact cannibal-demonesses, and later returned to rid the island of this plague. By the time of Atiśa, they seem to have returned and taken up the ancient custom again.

As an introduction to the account of Atiśa’s journey (which is recounted in the first person), here is what Atiśa’s biography says about the reasons for the voyage:

From among all these gurus, the one unencompassable by thought, absolutely matchless, without rival, was Guru Suvarṇadvīpa, “the Golden Islander.” His name was Dharmakīrti, “Dharma Fame.” Although he lived on Golden Island [Sumatra], his fame pervaded the entire [Buddhist] world and he was like the crown jewel of all Buddhists. It was said that he was the foremost teacher of [the training in] loving-kindness and compassion, and when the Lord [Atiśa] heard about him, [he was confident that] the Golden Island teacher had been his guru over innumerable previous lives. Merely by hearing his name, an extraordinary faith and devotion arose in him. Greatly affected in mind, he joined a group of merchants on their way to get precious stones from Golden Island, and set out in a great ship. They sailed through the poisonous ocean, through the milky ocean, through the ocean invading the land, and so forth.

Jo bo rje dpal ldan mar me mdzad ye shes kyi nram thar rgyas pa
(Varanasi: E. Kalsang, 1970), p. 132.

The translation below is from ‘Brom ston pa, *Bla ma’i yon tan chos kyi ’byung gnas* (Varanasi: E. Kalsang, 1969), section 2, *Jo bo gser du byon pa’i nram thar*.

How the Guru, in His Search for the Dharma, Coped with
Difficult Circumstances
The Story of How, In the Ocean, He Conquered the Deity Maheśvara

To the precious lords Maitreya and powerful Avalokiteśvara, in full prostration
I offer salutation.

I, the monk Dīpaṃkara Śrījñāna [Atiśa], for thirteen months was on board a ship, on my way into the presence of the guru of Golden Island.

When five months had passed [on board], a son of the gods (*devaputra*), Maheśvara [Śiva], in order to destroy my aspiration to achieve enlightenment for the sake of others (*bodhicitta*), caused a storm to move in, blowing in the wrong direction. Changing himself into the great Makara ["Fish Swallower"] sea monster, he obstructed [our passage] in front. From the sky he caused a thunderbolt to fall right on top of me. At that time, due to my meditating on loving-kindness [wishing all beings to be happy] and compassion [wishing no living being to experience suffering], the tempest was completely calmed and I saw six great bolts of lightning stuck motionless in the sky.

Yet the Makara sea monster was still blocking [our progress] in front, and the surface of the ocean was being churned about by this strong wind with such force that this ship of ours, too, like a prayer flag flapping in a strong wind, was rocking and rolling all about. One moment it was lifted toward the sky, the next moment it seemed to be plunging into the very depths of the ocean. The four great banners, one in each direction, broke off. Although four massive iron weights had been let down [as anchors] into the depths of the ocean, from each of the four directions, it was as if a massive drum was being beaten, with a howling noise, a thundering sound, light [at the horizon] and great flashes of lightning erupting, all of which made every one of the companions extremely frightened. As they were thus trembling in fear, again I entered into equipoise, meditating on loving-kindness and compassion.

Then Paṇḍita Kṣitigarbha, the great scholar, addressed his guru [me] with the following prayer:

Arise, please arise [from your meditation], compassionate guru,
If indeed you are without rival on earth.

This terror and agitation [of ours] caused by evil forces—
Out of your great compassion please pacify it; thus we pray.

If you [can] liberate all living beings from the ocean of existence,
[intervene here, because]

These evil forces threaten us now.

E MA! A tempest is moving us about and "the sky-metal" of thunder is
coming down on us like hell.

A colossal Fish Swallower is causing terror right in front.

Most Precious Lord, from these terrors be our refuge; thus we pray.

Moved about by the ocean winds, the waves reach up to heaven,
 A terrible noise resounds, hurting the ear, and there is the moving light
 of lightning,
 While the ship too is rocking this way, rocking that way, rolling and
 rolling from side to side, in endless motion,
 Rising up into the sky on a great wave, then flung down again into the
 depths.
 O may this Most Precious Lord be our refuge from these terrors; thus
 we pray.

In the vast sky of your excellent qualities,
 The close helpers: dharma protectors and guardians, entire assemblies
 like sky-soaring garuḍas,
 All-pervading, surrounding [you], if they do indeed clear away
 obstacles
 Yet ignore our present hindrances without being a haven of
 protection—
 That compassion [of theirs] dwelling in the sphere of isolation, how
 poor it is!
 So now, assemblies of ḍākinīs and dharma protectors, inner, outer, and
 secret,
 Arhats, heroes, heroines, and wisdom deities,
 All the divine assemblies who rejoice in the forces of goodness,
 On all sides surround you; here and now in this great ocean [assisted
 by them],
 O guru, with the mass of your compassion, drive back [this evil]; thus
 we pray.

To the Lord Red Slayer of Death (Rakta-Yamāri),
 Surrounded by the entourage who terrifies the Lord of Death [Yama]:
 Invincible By Others [an epithet of the King of Wrath (Krodharāja)],
 Together with the Immovable Lord [Acalanātha and the others of] the
 assembly of the Ten Wrathful Ones,
 And the Goddess [Tārā] who protects from the eight terrors, [in your
 form as] Lady Blazing Forth Auspiciousness and Splendor,
 [And] King of Dharma; Guru, in great numbers drive back [this evil];
 thus we pray.

Lord of the Teachings, Precious Bhagavān Buddha,
 Precious Avalokiteśvara, with your maṇḍala devoid of all impurity,
 Dharmarājas, father and son, who clear away the misery of
 transmigrators,
 The time has come! Bring forth your compassionate family in great
 numbers!
 Extend the river of your stainless blessings; thus we pray.

In this way, with a clear voice he spoke his special prayer and I heard it. Then I [turned into] the Bhagavān Slayer of Death [Yamāri], [my] body red, with a fat belly, dark brown hair waving upward, with reddish eyes wide open looking into the ten directions. As soon as this was seen, I let all the other hand-embblems fall, I raised the vajra cudgel into the sky [with my right hand] and with the left [hand] in threatening [mudrā] I swung a lasso. With a blow of the vajra cudgel I struck the world mountain, thereby smashing the world mountain to pieces, and below the world mountain, all the way down to the golden foundation [of the world], I cut open and laid bare. Back and forth the great ocean was roiled and became like boiling blood. This fish-swallowing Makara sea monster was [soon reduced to] pure white bones, then suddenly changed into a child, a young girl, completely emaciated and of blue color. Suddenly appearing on board ship, she offered prostrations, then with her palms joined in front of her, she spoke:

King of Wrath, mighty in powers and forces, Krodha rāja,
 Mahākaruṇika, Great Compassionate One, sole refuge for
 transmigrators,
 I, now terrified, I who truly committed so many mistakes,
 Now pray to you, out of your great compassion, please protect me.

Thus she spoke; and I, still wielding the vajra cudgel, [replied]:

Hum! I am the great master over the life of living beings!
 Being the power of compassion, I,
 Out of pity for you, did not liberate [kill] you.
 Now do not teach the erroneous religion of the Tīrthikas
 To my disciples!
 Girl, do not expound the false religion of Bōn!
 Your life, your survival is in my power.

Thus I spoke. She said:

These melodious verses I offer,
 Great Compassionate One, please listen, thus I pray.
 To these disciples of yours [in Tibet],
 No erroneous teachings will I give;
 Please have kind thoughts toward me;
 Over my life you are the master indeed.

In this way she spoke. Then from the bottom of the fire hearth [on board], one human figure of white complexion suddenly arose, [telling me:]

Do not [ever] travel to the Land of Snows [Tibet];
 And stop your journey on this Nepalese ship.
 Do not go to either Copper Island [Sri Lanka] or any of the other small
 islands.

Stop this continuous roaming!
 Bhrum hṛi yakṣa, listen to this!

Thereupon the stormy weather calmed down altogether, the waves, the light [of far-away lightning], the noise all became pacified. The great ship too quietly resumed its course, while all on board gave out a sigh of relief and engaged in joyful conversation among themselves.

Yet I, without breaking up my generation stage [visualization] of [myself as] the wrathful Slayer of Death, Yamāri, from the back of the ship I settled the clear appearance of the deity, like an image of bronze with the nature of rainbow light. Then, I fixed the vajra cudgel to the mast.

Then the great vessel did not make the slightest movement any more but remained steady like a residential building. As this occurred, I wondered: "What's this?" and went to have a look, then heard some girls engaged in joyful talk and laughter. As soon as I looked in that direction, now [manifesting myself] as the king of the wrathful [circle of protector deities], Acala the Immovable, I waded through the depths of the ocean, which only reached up to my knees. Then like a young man picking up a wooden trough by starboard and port, I made it move. With my crown amidst the clouds, I caused a wind to arise.

All around the ship there were twenty-one girls who now turned their heads, speaking: "If it had not been for us sisters, would you have been such a great lord today?" to which I [replied]:

To the lady guarding from the eight terrors, I offer salutation in full prostration.

To the lady who makes auspiciousness and good fortune blaze forth, I offer salutation in full prostration.

To the lady shutting the gate to [rebirth in] evil existences, I offer salutation in full prostration.

To the lady guiding us to heavenly abodes, I offer salutation in full prostration.

May you at all times accompany us and assist us.

At present, out of compassion, please protect us, I pray.

I addressed this prayer [to the twenty-one Tārās]. These girls spoke: "Had it not been for the presence of [our] son Kṣitigarbha, we were just thinking: "Let's reduce that Tirthika city Svabhanatha to ashes," when we heard his voice in prayer. Father [Atiśa], you are supreme among all sentient beings, yet he is a mahāsattva, a great hero. In fact we have come here because of his strong request and invitation. [Also] if that child with the blue face again recovers, beat her!" they said, [adding]: "From this day forward, do not allow her outside this ship of Nepal!"

Next they exhorted Kṣitigarbha: "Most venerable one, scatter these flowers

from the sky onto Svabhanatha. We girls will take upon ourselves the [karmic] responsibility [of your breaking your vows of] refuge and the altruistic aspiration to enlightenment [by engaging in this violent act]. The paṇḍit Kṣitigarbha with a threatening mudrā cast one lightning flash. Having gone around in a circle, at the northern side of the Tīrthika city Svabhanatha, it came down right on top of the [image of] goddess Carcika that was the established there, crushing the Tīrthika temple, including the [image of the] goddess. He shot forth another [flash of lightning] and it hit the sacred image of Maheśvara itself and cracked it to dust.

One shaft of light from it hit the Tīrthika king and burned dry his right side; another shaft of light hit the Turuka palace in the [Afghan] borderlands, and for thirteen years the Mongol hordes were stopped from reaching [and raiding] the Vajra Throne [Bodhgayā]. Yet another light ray struck the Black Tent palace of the king of Shang-Shung, causing the teachings of Bön to go down. Only a couple of their [teachers] here and there survived, and in distress they fled into the Himalayan mountain ranges. One light ray, directed at the poison lake in the south, hit the palace of Kṛṣṇa, stopping short the burning disease of leprosy. One ray of light struck Lanka, the country of the rakṣasa cannibal-demons, and put a stop to the cannibal-demons' tradition of eating human flesh. Then he spoke these words of [divine] pride:

Of this maṇḍala-residence of the earth, am I the master; therefore,
Evil circumstances and conditions, scatter, disperse, be reduced to
dust!

The Great Hero [Slayer of Death] is my master.
In Uddhyana country, Hāyagrīva, King Horseneck neighs with a voice
of a horse.

Destroy, destroy Maheśvara, reduce him to ashes;
Eliminate the gods of Bön and the magic that is their essence!
Om padmāntakṛta vajrakrodha hāyagrīva hulu hulu huṃ phaṭ!"

Thus I heard him say. Next the king of wrath Acala the Immovable, and the Bhagavān [Yamāri Slayer of Death] himself suddenly became invisible, and I showed again forth my own form as a monk and remained as such.

All the followers in my entourage greatly rejoiced:
"Spontaneously arisen, not fabricated
King of dharma, similar to a hill of precious stones,
On account of this ultimate wisdom, [as revealed by] signs supreme,
All of us are extremely pleased.
E ma ho! Lord with powers and strengths,
Tathāgata from the ocean
That terrified us, please hear us,

And under the protection of your compassion,
Without error, gave us shelter, thus we pray!"

Thus they spoke. For twenty-one days we were utterly unable to continue, but as soon as we were truly safe from further fear, on each of the four directions [of the ship] we raised the great wind banners, we hauled up the four massive iron [anchor weights]. Then, as an opportune wind arose for one and a half months without break by day or night, we remained on the great ocean and proceeded.

After seven months had passed, again, from in front, a storm arose and we were driven back by the wind over the distance of one day's travel. I prayed to my guru, to the precious three, and to the *ḍākinis* and *dharma* protectors. Soon the storm subsided by itself, yet a strong wind in the right direction failed to arise. Because of the [little] merit of the sentient beings [on board], half a month was lost there, during which I meditated on the aspiration to enlightenment based on loving-kindness and compassion. Eventually a right wind arose and we took off again. It took us a further two months and twenty-six days to reach the shore across the ocean.

[Colophon] From the exposition of how the Guru, in his search for the *dharma*, coped with difficult circumstances: the exposition of the story of how, in the ocean, he conquered *Maheśvara*.

